

# PK LAWTON

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## EXECUTIVE PROFILE

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Senior brand strategy executive who co-founded, scaled, and exited Sister Merci (a 30-person, two-country strategy-led creative agency) over seven years (2019–2026). As CSO and Co-Founder, I raised \$1.5M in seed capital, developed 150+ brands, won 7 Clios (including Cannabis Agency of the Year 2023). Previously VP Strategy at Cossette and Weber Shandwick, leading work for Air Canada, RBC, Canopy Growth, Mondelez, and Chevrolet.

Built for high-friction categories (cannabis, iGaming, alcohol, fintech, AI) where my unique combination of ethnographic research, regulatory navigation, and design discipline separates good work from category-defining work. Currently teaching as an Adjunct Professor at McMaster, and am a co-founding editor of Rebrief: A New Canadian Journal of Advertising, a print magazine launching July 2026.

**Known for:** building strategy functions that earn their seat in pitches and growth, translating fieldwork into creative fuel, and designing category-defining work in markets where the easy playbook no longer applies.

## LEADERSHIP COMPETENCIES

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Brand Strategy & Architecture | Cultural Insight & Ethnographic Research | Category & Audience Strategy | Integrated & Full-Funnel Communications | CX, CRM & Loyalty Strategy | Creative Briefing  
New Business & Pitch Leadership | C-Suite Client Advisory | Strategy Team Leadership & Mentorship  
Thought Leadership & Public Voice

## CAREER HIGHLIGHTS

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- **Co-founded, scaled, and exited Sister Merci (2019–2026):** built from 4 founders to 30+ staff across Toronto and Chicago; 150+ brands; \$1.5M raised from BlackShire Capital; 85%+ pitch win rate; 3× Agency of the Year (Clio Cannabis 2023, ADCANN 2022, KIND 2021); 7 Clios.
- **Led “I’m High Right Now” for the Cannabis Media Council:** first nationwide consumer cannabis campaign in the U.S. 256M earned impressions, first cannabis ad in Vanity Fair, first cannabis campaign on Spotify, Adweek Top 10. Changed U.S. publisher advertising policy.
- **Led RBC Future Launch audience identification** at Weber Shandwick: strategic foundation for a \$500M, 10-year youth commitment.
- Co-founded **Rebrief: A Canadian Journal of Advertising** (launching July 2026): non-profit editorial platform for Canadian strategic thinking, with strategy leaders from BHLA, ZAK, Mosaic, and FUSE.

## PROFESSIONAL EXPERIENCE

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### Co-Founder & Chief Strategy Officer

*Sister Merci | Toronto & Chicago*

**2019 – 2026 (Exited May 2026)**

Co-founded Sister Merci with two partners after a \$1.5M raise from BlackShire Capital. Scaled the agency from 4 founders to 30+ staff across two countries; 150+ brands across cannabis, iGaming, alcohol, CPG, fintech, health tech, and AI; 85%+ pitch win rate; 85%+ tier-one client retention. 7 Clios, 3× Agency of the Year (Clio Cannabis 2023, ADCANN 2022, KIND 2021). Press in Adweek, Forbes, Ad Age, Strategy, Financial Post, and Campaign Canada.

- Built the agency-as-brand-lab operating model for regulated and vice categories, combining longitudinal category analysis with ethnographic research to deliver category-defining brand and campaign work. Clients included Canopy Growth, Organigram, Hexo, Tilray, Casino Time, MadeGood, NiaHealth, Doodle, Manulife, and MosaicAI.

- Led “I’m High Right Now” for the Cannabis Media Council: 256M earned impressions, first cannabis ad in Vanity Fair, first cannabis campaign on Spotify, Adweek Top 10, Hearst Super Bowl preview feature. Changed U.S. publisher advertising policy.
- Owned creative brief quality across 150+ engagements, operating a triumvirate model with creative and business leadership to move original, culturally grounded work from insight to execution.
- Served as senior brand strategist and C-suite advisor to founders and CMOs across brand architecture, purpose definition, innovation roadmaps, and customer experience strategy.
- Built and mentored the strategy team through the Square-Shaped Strategist model: a cross-disciplinary training framework that produced senior strategy hires placed across the Canadian and U.S. industry.
- Led every new-business pitch to 85%+ win rate, drove organic growth, and engineered a reverse-takeover acquisition of U.S.-based Receptor Brands (2023) for U.S. market entry.

#### **Fractional Chief Marketing Officer**

**2023 – 2024**

*Galaxie Brands*

- Led brand strategy, positioning, and go-to-market for WYLD gummies’ Canadian market entry: +16.5% compound monthly growth rate in launch year. ADCANN Packaging and Edible of the Year.
- Built the CRUZY brand from zero: positioning platform, identity, go-to-market strategy, and retail activation.

#### **Vice President, Strategy**

**2018 – 2019**

*Cossette | Toronto*

- Led market insights and brand strategy for the Canopy Growth portfolio through Canadian cannabis legalization: Tweed, DNA Genetics, Foria: shaping category-defining positioning in a newly regulated market.
- Co-managed a 20-person strategy department across brand, digital, and media planning. Built strategic craft, briefing discipline, and commercial acumen across the team.

#### **Vice President, Strategic Planning**

**2016 – 2018**

*Weber Shandwick | Toronto*

- Led strategic planning for Air Canada (Aeroplan transition and loyalty strategy) and RBC (Future Launch audience identification for a \$500M, 10-year youth commitment); also led work for Mondelez and Chevrolet.
- Developed audience-first, behaviourally grounded communications strategies across paid, earned, owned, and shared channels.

#### **Senior Counsellor & Digital Lead**

**2013 – 2016**

*Cohn & Wolfe | Toronto*

- Directed a 237-person ethnographic field study for CN Rail’s Milton community engagement: surfaced a human truth that reversed a decade of community opposition. Employee of the Year, 2015.
- Led integrated digital, content, and earned media strategy for Nissan, Nintendo, CN Rail, and Dell.
- Built the agency’s first analytics and measurement framework for integrated digital communications.

### **BOARD, ADVISORY & INDUSTRY LEADERSHIP**

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#### **Co-Founding Editor & Treasurer**

**2025 – Present**

*Rebrief Magazine Society: A Canadian Journal of Advertising*

Non-profit editorial platform; first issue July 2026. Co-founded with strategy leaders from BHLA, ZAK, Mosaic, and FUSE.

#### **Chair, Marketing & Advertising Committee**

**2025**

*National Cannabis Industry Association*

#### **Strategic Advisor**

**2024 – 2025**

*Cannabis Standards Alliance of Canada*

## TEACHING & THOUGHT LEADERSHIP

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### **Adjunct Professor, Brand Strategy & Consumer Research**

**2020 – Present**

*McMaster University Continuing Education*

Teaches Brand Strategy, Consumer Research, Introduction to Marketing, Personal Branding, and Effective Presentations. Redesigned curriculum for platform fragmentation and AI disruption. Partnered with the Canadian Marketing Association on an accelerated pathway to the Chartered Marketer designation.

### **Publishing & Speaking**

**2020 – Present**

*Various*

LBB Online (2025), Strategy Online (2020), ongoing Substack on strategy as field practice (Bourdieu, Actor-Network Theory, Institutional Ethnography). Keynote: APG Canada (future of market research, 2024); Cannabis Council of Canada (Reddit's impact on brand performance, 2024).

### **Adjunct Assistant Professor, Sociology** | University of Lethbridge | 2007 – 2012

*Taught Digital Culture and Society (5 years), Mass Communications and Society, Sociology of Health.*

## EDUCATION

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**PhD (ABD), Sociology** | University of Calgary | 2006 – 2010 · Dissertation: Internet-mediated doctor-patient relationships. SSHRC PhD Fellowship recipient.

**MA, Sociology** | University of Lethbridge | 2003 – 2005 · Alberta Gaming Research Institute funded. Thesis cited in Yale Journal of Law & Technology.

**BA (Great Distinction), Sociology** | University of Lethbridge | 1999 – 2003